

The Help Ladder



BIG IDEA When something online feels wrong, telling someone is the strongest move. Climb the Ladder until someone helps.

1 HOOK 2'

2 ACTIVITY 8'

3 DISCUSS 3'

4 TAKEAWAY 2'

PREP IN 5 MINUTES

Materials: Ladder poster (R-0), Trusted Hand worksheet (p. 1), Ladder Scenario Cards (R-1.1), pencils.

- ☐ Draw a ladder with three blank rungs on the board.
- ☐ Copy the Trusted Hand worksheet; one card set per group.
- ☐ Know your counselor and your reporting route.

1 HOOK 2 MIN *60-second script* Raise your hand if you have ever gotten stuck on a hard video-game level. Keep it up if you asked for help. “Almost everyone! Pros ask for help all the time. Kenji was playing a game when a message popped up: ‘Hi! I’ll give you 500 free coins if you click here.’ He felt a tingle that said ‘hmm.’ He did not click. He paused, he checked, and he told Aunt Lin. She said, ‘Thank you for telling me. You did exactly the right thing.’ Telling is not tattling, and it is never getting in trouble. Today we learn the Help Ladder.”

2 ACTIVITY 8 MIN *Climb the Ladder*

- 1 (1 min) The rungs.** Rung 1: tell a friend you trust. Rung 2: tell a trusted adult. Rung 3: report it (counselor, principal, helpline, report button). “If a rung does not work, keep climbing.”
- 2 (1 min) Trusted Hand.** Five trusted adults, one per finger.
- 3 (1 min) Sentence starters,** said aloud: “I need help with something online.” “Something happened and I’m not sure what to do.” “I’m not in trouble. I just need to tell you something.”
- 4 (4 min) Triads.** Teller reads a card, picks the rung, says the first sentence. Listener: “Thank you for telling me. It is not your fault. Let’s figure it out together.” Observer: one star, one wish. Rotate.
- 5 (1 min) Two volunteers show it.** Applaud the Teller, not the story.

3 DISCUSS 3 MIN

- 1** “Why do some kids feel nervous about telling?” (Accept all answers.)
- 2** “What if the first grown-up says, ‘I’m busy right now’? What is your next move?”
- 3** “Does Tell mean you did something wrong?” (No. You are being smart.)

4 TAKEAWAY 2 MIN “When something online feels off, your hackles go up. Climb the Ladder even if it is a false alarm. Telling is never your fault. Pause, check, tell, and keep climbing until someone helps.”

Hand signal: Hackles Up (hand brushed up the neck), Pause (palm), Check (magnifier fingers), Tell (hand on chest, then out).

EXIT TICKET “Write one grown-up you can tell and the first sentence you would say.” A student who writes “nobody” gets a private follow-up with the counselor.

FUN BOOST Ladder Climb (30 seconds). Mime climbing three rungs with big knee lifts, chanting “Friend! Grown-up! Report!” On the top rung shout “Keep climbing!”

LEVEL-UP Ladder for a Friend. Write what you would say if a friend told YOU something scary, then teach the Ladder to a younger reading buddy.

DIFFERENTIATE Give the Teller a sentence-starter strip; allow drawing on the Trusted Hand.

FAMILY CARD Ask: “Who are your five trusted people?” Reply: “Thank you for telling me. You are not in trouble.”

IF A STUDENT TELLS YOU SOMETHING

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| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> • Say: “Thank you for telling me. You did the right thing.” • “This is not your fault, and you are not in trouble.” • “I can’t keep this a secret, because I need to get you help. I will tell you who I tell.” | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> • Do not say: “I promise I won’t tell anyone.” • “Are you sure?” or “Why didn’t you tell me sooner?” • Anything beyond “Can you tell me more?” |
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First 10 Minutes: see the Disclosure Guide.

Then: tell your counselor or designated person right away. Follow your school policy and your state’s reporting law.